

Prime Focus

Official Newsletter of QRAA

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Farm Management Grants of up to \$2,500 now available

Building and implementing a robust succession plan for your family has just become more affordable, with the introduction of the Queensland Government's Farm Management Grants this month.

The grants help producers offset the costs of succession planning with rebates of up to \$2,500 for professional advice related to family farm transfers. Eligible advice includes (but is not limited to) that received from solicitors, accountants, financial advisors and succession planners. Any Queensland primary producer, or their relatives with an interest in the primary production enterprise can now apply.

Good succession plans play a vital role both in helping hardworking Queenslanders retire comfortably and keeping the next generation on the land. Chief Executive Officer Cameron MacMillan is thrilled that we can offer this funding to help secure the future of the rural sector.

"Succession can be a complex process, and a weak – or non-existent plan can have a devastating effect on not just the future of farming businesses, but on family relationships," he said.

"Receiving professional help from trusted experts can make all the difference in ensuring a family farm transfer is as smooth as possible. By making it more affordable to access this advice, we're removing yet another obstacle in what can be an expensive process."

QRAA has been allocated with funding of up to \$3 million to deliver Farm Management Grants for at least three financial years. Producers and their relatives can apply for a rebate of up to \$2,500 per year.

To take full advantage of the scheme and receive a grant in 2016-17, producers are



urged to apply as soon as possible. A pre-approval process is in place to encourage producers and their relatives to start the succession conversation right now.

The application itself is a quick, easy process that can be completed via our new online application portal, or submitted via email.

"We know that the end of financial year is approaching and that getting the family together for a meeting can take a while – so we're relieving some of the time pressures and allowing you to submit a claim in advance" Mr MacMillan said.

"This means that you can engage your chosen professional and proceed with full confidence that a rebate will be paid once you've got the advice."

For more information visit www.qraa.qld.gov.au

Cyclone Debbie - QRAA's response

Many Queenslanders felt the full force of Severe Tropical Cyclone Debbie and associated rainfall and flooding in late March and April. Turn to our back page for full details of QRAA's response and the loan and grant assistance now available for affected producers, small businesses and non-profit organisations.

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**Queensland
Government**

From the CEO's desk



QRAA CEO, Cameron MacMillan

Tropical Cyclone Debbie and associated flooding wreaked havoc for many primary producers and small businesses from Bowen to Beaudesert during March.

QRAA is again playing a lead role in delivering the financial assistance now activated under the joint State and Commonwealth disaster recovery arrangements. Since the disaster, QRAA has had staff on the ground and via its Freecall number responding to hundreds of queries about the recovery grants and concessional loans available.

See the back page of this *Prime Focus* for more details on this natural disaster assistance including our new online portal that is making the grant application process simpler and easier.

With a record year behind us and exciting things in the pipeline, the rest of 2017 is shaping up to be full of potential for QRAA clients and the wider Queensland agriculture industry.

By the end of February, we had approved a record \$100 million in First Start and Sustainability Loans. The Department of Agriculture and Fisheries then committed a further \$20 million in funding for these programs which was fully allocated by the end of March, and an additional \$30 million for prawn farmers affected by white spot disease.

To support this strong demand I'm thrilled to announce that QRAA has opened a new office and recruited Janessa Bidgood as our new Regional Area Manager based in Cloncurry. A local to the area, Janessa is helping

producers from Winton to the Gulf with their applications for all of QRAA's financial assistance and loan programs.

Also new to QRAA are our Farm Management Grants which, following the increased limits on our First Start Loans and the removal of stamp duty on family farm transfers last year, are helping make rural succession more affordable and realistic than ever.

With the Farm Business Debt Mediation Bill recently passed, even more changes are coming for QRAA from 1 July, with expanded roles including the compulsory farm debt mediation scheme, a farm debt restructure advisory service and a new broader focus and name as the Queensland Rural and Industry Development Authority (QRIDA).

It's sure to be an exciting time and we look forward to working with you over coming months.

Cameron MacMillan

New Cloncurry office & Regional Area Managers

We are thrilled to announce that North West producers will receive local, personalised support to tackle drought and improve business profitability as we open a ninth regional office.

The North West and Gulf office will be based in Cloncurry, with local Janessa Bidgood appointed to the newly established role of Regional Area Manager for the area. Janessa is already known to many producers in the region as her family are well recognised in grazing, real estate and rodeo circles.

The recent changes to our First Start and Sustainability Loans and the proactive, driven community in Cloncurry made it a natural fit for our newest base.

The increase in maximum amounts available under First Start and Sustainability Loans, to \$2 million and \$1.3 million respectively, has made them more attractive and relevant to North West producers.

Where properties are larger and essential investments – from improvements to family succession – can be costlier, these loans now have the potential to make a real impact.



Janessa Bidgood - Regional Area Manager for North West and Gulf

The addition of a ninth office also means our existing QRAA regional network can more readily cover their areas and provide prompt service to our clients now and in times of natural disaster.

We also have John Lacey joining us as Regional Area Manager for Capricornia, based in our Rockhampton office. John comes to us following several years as a Rural Financial Counsellor based in Biloela, and is sure to be an asset to current and future clients of QRAA.

Contact John and Janessa on **Freecall 1800 623 946** or visit the Regional Service page on our website for their full contact details.



John Lacey - Regional Area Manager for Capricornia

Meet with QRAA at local events

May

- 19-20** Canegrowers Mackay AG Trade Expo (Mackay)
- 20** Longreach Show
- 24-26** Far North QLD Field Days (Mareeba)

June

- 6-8** CRT FarmFest Field Days (Toowoomba)
- 9-10** Richmond Field Days (Richmond)
- 22-24** Australian Banana Industry Congress (Sydney)

First Start in action - keeping Queensland's youth on the land



First Start Loan client Luke Apap on his cane farm near Tully

Some young people have to be bribed and begged into working on the family farm, but not Luke Apap of Tully. Growing up on a sugarcane and banana farm, the young producer's grandfather was showing him the ropes by the time he was six, and by eight he was starting to pull his weight in the family business – “not because I had to, but because I wanted to,” says Luke.

“...QRAA understands the challenges of life on the land.”

Now, Luke runs his own canefarm providing 5,000 tonnes annually to the Tully Sugar Mill, the same place he is completing a diesel fitting apprenticeship.

Still in his teens at the time, he purchased the property in 2015 with the help of a QRAA First Start Loan, and hasn't looked back.

“I have always loved farming, so when the opportunity came up and with plenty of encouragement and support from my parents, I decided to give it a go,” he said.

The small parcel of land served as the ideal, manageable launching pad for a staged approach to full-time production, while the close proximity

to his parents' well-established farm meant that Luke was able to share in their resources, saving him from some costly hurdles many new producers face.

“My parents had been looking at the property and it wasn't what they were looking for – but being within four kilometres from my parents' farm, it was the perfect location as I would be able to use their equipment.”

Now 20 years old, Luke has his sights set on completing his apprenticeship and gradually expanding his canefarm, continuing in his trade until he has built a profitable, productive enterprise that can support him full time. He recommends that other young people looking to do the same consider a First Start Loan from QRAA.

“Being focussed on agriculture, QRAA understand the challenges of life on the land,” he said.

“The First Start Loan is great, and provides better interest rates than any other lender for anyone who wants to begin their career in agriculture.”

When putting together his application, Luke took advantage of the assistance from his local QRAA representative, saying “Sam Spina was a great help – he took the time to come out to the farm and helped me through the application step by step.”

First Start Loans provide up to \$2 million to assist in the early years of establishing a primary production business, allowing for a staged approach like Luke's. The loans feature interest rates as low as 3.11 per cent, with 20 year repayment terms and up to five years interest-only.

Young Queenslanders interested in pursuing their goal of full time production and families looking to start their succession plan can find out more at www.qraa.qld.gov.au/firststart.

Drought Assistance

Despite Tropical Cyclone Debbie's devastation of a significant part of Queensland, much of the state is still feeling the effects of the drought.

QRAA has received an extra \$15 million in funding from the Australian Government for Drought Assistance Concessional Loans, boosting the total funding for the program to \$50 million.

These loans of up to \$1 million have an interest rate of just 2.47% and can be used to restructure debt, restock and replant, or invest in future drought preparedness.

With the scheme closing 30 June 2017, contact your local Regional Area Manager and start the discussion about how these loans can help you.

Tropical Cyclone Debbie response

Financial help for those impacted by Tropical Cyclone Debbie

Primary producers, small businesses and non-profit organisations impacted by Severe Tropical Cyclone Debbie and associated flooding can access a range of financial assistance from QRAA to help them get back on their feet in the aftermath of the cyclone.

QRAA was quick to respond to the cyclone which devastated many communities up and down the Queensland coast, putting extra staff on the ground in the affected areas, establishing a new online portal for grant assistance applications and responding directly to more than 2,000 enquiries about the help available.

There is currently three types of financial assistance available from QRAA for those in the disaster declared areas:

- Recovery grants up to \$25,000
- Natural Disaster Assistance low interest loans of up to \$250,000
- Essential Working Capital low interest loans of up to \$100,000.

Recovery Grants up to \$25,000

Eligible primary producers, small businesses and non-profit organisations can apply for initial Recovery Grants of up to \$5,000 prior to incurring clean-up and restoration costs.

Applicants simply need to provide evidence of the direct damage, such as photographs and quotations, although tax invoices and official receipts are to be supplied if available.

Subsequent grant amounts up to a total of \$20,000 to assist with additional cleaning and reinstatement costs can also be accessed – this further funding requires full evidence of completion of works and payment.

Eligible costs include purchasing, hiring or leasing equipment or materials to clean premises or property or to immediately resume farming activities, removing or disposing of debris, repairing or replacing fencing and repairing or reconditioning essential plant or equipment.

QRAA administers this assistance under the joint Commonwealth/Queensland Government funded Natural Disaster Relief and Recovery Arrangements (NDRRA).



Proserpine canegrower, Paul Atkinson, showing the effects of TC Debbie on his property to QRAA CEO, Cameron MacMillan

Grants can also help cover the costs of contractors or additional employee wages to assist with clean-up work, as well as additional fuel, oil and other costs incurred in the use of their own equipment.

How to access recovery grants

QRAA has established a new online grants portal (accessible through QRAA's website) where applicants can directly complete and submit applications and supporting documentation.

Alternatively, applicants or their advisors can download the grant application form and guidelines from QRAA's website to submit via email or post.

Natural Disaster Loans

Concessional loans of up to \$250,000 are available to eligible producers who have suffered direct damage to cover activities such as replanting crops and repairing buildings.

For those who suffered loss of income, Essential Working Capital Loans of up to \$100,000 can help to pay wages, creditors and other working expenses.

Both of these loans are provided at a rate of just 1.16% for a period of up to seven years - including up to two years interest only.

Tips on how to apply

Follow the tips below to make sure your application for assistance is submitted correctly:

- **Visit www.qraa.qld.gov.au** for full information on the grants and loans available, including FAQs, declared areas, the online application portal, application forms and scheme guidelines
- **Talk to QRAA on Freecall 1800 623 946** (8am - 5pm, Monday - Friday) for application queries or to speak directly with a QRAA representative in your region
- **Check if you are in a disaster declared area** by reviewing the most recent natural disaster activation notice, available on QRAA's website
- **Make sure you provide evidence of the direct damage** with your grant application, such as photos and quotations, and tax invoices and receipts for the subsequent grant amount
- **Remember the closing date for grant applications** is 13 October 2017

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